MODINOMICS HITS & MISSES

INTERVIEW | NIRMALA SITHARAMAN

"IN MODI 3.0, TECH-DRIVEN CHANGES WILL BE OUR TOP PRIORITY"

As General Election 2024 gets under way, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman has stepped out of the hallowed precincts of North Block into the heat and dust of the electoral battlefield. Despite that hectic campaigning schedule, she finds time for an in-depth interview with Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Managing Editor M.G. Arun, shedding light on a whole gamut of issues around the economy, including uncomfortable ones like unemployment and inflation, and what we can expect from Modi 3.0 if the BJP comes to power a third consecutive time. Edited excerpts from the interview:

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Q. It has been 10 years of Modinomics. What would you say have been the four main pillars of the Modi government's policies that have seen the economy not just recover after the pandemic but do so with a robust growth of 7.6 per cent?

The four things that readily come to my mind are: the effort taken to remove that wrong perception about India that you're capable of nothing, that you can't really come up, that you're corrupt, that your red-tapism will be permanent.... Second, ensuring that policies were in tandem with people and their requirements—not so radical that they get rejected, but taking India up the ladder, stable policies that would attract people towards our country, give our own citizens that confidence that governments can deliver and deliver not just for the poor and the needy but also for systems to be improved. Third, making sure you identify areas in which India's policies are tailored to meet the demands of the 21st century, including sustainable growth. And fourth, identify areas in which India can lead globally, invest in them and support people to go into them and give India the advantage.